5: Socialization and Interaction

Socialization

In the last unit, we established how meaning is one of the central components of sociology, and particularly its components, of values, norms, and material culture. It remains to be seen, however, how people come to know these elements of society. This process, in turn, is called **socialization**.

Socialization is the ongoing process, beginning at birth, through which people develop an awareness of social norms and values and achieve a distinct sense of self.

One key out put of the process of socialization is the distinctive senses of self that we (and, at a more macro-level, groups) develop relative to society at large and other people and groups. For instance (and as we will discuss later in the course), to answer the question "what makes you *you*," in contemporary developed societies we would typically answer with a variety of markers—our gender, our race, perhaps our religion, our national origin, and so on. We call these markers of who we are **identity**, and we further recognize that the concept contains a dynamic between two elements: what people think is categorically distinctive about us (**social identities** ascribed to us) and how those categories intersect, or stand in tension with, our senses of "who we really are" (our **self-identity**).

Identity is the distinctive intersection for a person or group of who they are and what is meaningful to them. It is composed of the dynamic between **social-identities**, the significant categories attributed to people and groups by others, and **self-identity**, which is how those categories affect a person or groups' understanding of themselves.

As if that were not complex enough, our identities and socialization often relate, in turn, to our **social roles.** As noted by Erving Goffman (about whom more later in this unit), a social role has a close connection with the idea of a theatrical role—there are expectations about how you should act and react, in a given context, if you are to persuasively "give off" the markers of a good performance of that role. Think of being a part of your family (another key social- and self-identity for many

people): there are expectations for how parents and children should behave, and those are related to one another; a parent *should* guide a child's development, and a child *should* explore the world in light of that guidance but also show devotion and perhaps support to their parent.

In the context of our class together (the relevant **social setting**), I have the social role of a professor, which means that you can expect me to provide you a coherent introduction to the material announced in the course, and I can expect you as students (another social role) to try to understand the material, ask good-faith relevant questions, and so on. Likewise, I can depend on my Teaching Assistants to perform a role in the setting.

Social roles are defined expectations for behavior and social identity for a person given by a person's social position and the social setting for an interaction.

The **social setting** describes the time, place, and role expectations for people within an interaction.

Why Is Socialization Necessary?

There is some speculation that socialization has biological roots, specifically the obstetrical dilemma, which limits the maximum brain size at birth for bipedal primates.[1] By consequence of this fact, and also the sheer technical and cultural complexity of social life, it is simply impossible for people, at birth, to have all relevant cultural information necessary to exist as they do stored in their brains at the time of birth.

[1] This hypothesis has been questioned, but it remains true that regardless of the reasons for it, humans experience rapid increases in brain volume, which are much higher than primates and other mammals.

Who Socializes?

There are numerous groups who socialize you. Above all, there are those who provide your **primary socialization** in early childhood until your adolescence. These usually include your family and (it's in the name!) primary caregiver (whether a biological parent or otherwise) who teach you the initial stages of how to "be" in the world. This often includes teaching you to talk, care for yourself in a basic way[2], and restrain basic urges in the name of social norms.

[2] Yes, this includes potty training!

To get a sense of what primary socialization looks like in practice, think of dinner at a "family" restaurant. If you've gone with *your* family to such a restaurant, you know that it's not *always*

an experience that's so joyous you lose track of time. Maybe you don't like your cousin or sibling, or maybe a grandparent told you a story for the 30th time or commented about your appearance. You may have *wanted* to get up and storm out, pull out your phone, or even scream at the person, but you (hopefully) didn't, because you were "acting like an adult."

Compare this to the small children in other families at the restaurant.[3] In those cases, the children—because their primary socialization is not yet complete—tend to behave *very* differently. They actually act on those impulses, and may even throw food, break down crying, or get out of their seats and start crawling around or running between tables. And, assuming that the *parents* are normally socialized, you will witness primary socialization happening. "Timmy, shush while your nonna is talking," a parent might say to a child, "We don't interrupt!" Or, "it's not polite to spit out food you don't like!" Or, "If you keep crying, we'll leave." Or, "Make sure that you put your napkin on your lap, so that food doesn't get on your clothes!" All of those are examples of when social norms, values, and information about material culture is being directly and explicitly transmitted to children.

[3] Or maybe your family has small children in it. I don't know your life.

Running congruently with primary socialization as children grow into adulthood, **secondary socialization** is undertaken by media, family, work, and peer-groups. Vehicles of secondary socialization typically augment those of primary socialization, but also include those reaching far beyond an individual's direct sphere of ordinary interaction and including forms of socialization that a person might directly seek out for themselves.

Facing Primary Socialization

Here are two excellent examples of primary socialization.

The first is the famous still face experiment. Here, we can see the sheer intensity of socializing and cueing by young children. The apparatus of the experiment is for a mother to simply cease all interaction and hold a "still face" in front of their child. This is often taught as an example of interaction, but it's an equally powerful example of *socialization*, since the act of

interaction is the reward and punishment system of socialization. For instance, in the absence of positive reward from the mother (in the form of smiles, attention, and so on), one can easily observe the child's behavior literally regressing and becoming *less* socialized.

The second is a remarkable example of primary socialization in early-childhood education. In this case, the educator uses deft attention and explicit rewards (in the form of high-fives) to explicitly socialize young children (my guess is around 4) into collectively listening to him. Here, you can *also* see how social coordination is a vehicle for collective socialization; the children are not only experiencing bilateral interaction (between each of them and the teacher), they are also being socialized by the behavior of their peers (the other children). Further, it is worth noting that the inciting incident for the interaction that was recorded was that other children were going outside to play, and the children crying at the start of the video were left behind because they were misbehaving.

Ongoing Socialization

As noted above, secondary socialization continues throughout the life course and is differentiated from primary socialization because it typically includes a much wider set of social influences than primary socialization and also includes forms of socialization that people seek out for themselves.

Examples of this ongoing socialization abound. Consider just a few:

- a joke-y set of explanations about how to greet co-workers depending on familiarity
- a website that explains how and where to park on campus
- the federal government explaining what stocks are and how to buy and sell them
- rules of etiquette for how to behave in a mosque.[4]

[4] I could multiply these examples literally a thousand-fold in a very short time. I chose these because they show some of the micro- macro-sociological scope of ongoing socialization.

The Life Course: Categories of Socialization

As the depth and breadth of ongoing socialization implies, there are a vast web of social settings and subcultures that one may need socialization into. However, it is *also* the case that these settings and subcultures tend to be grouped together in terms of where we stand in our **life course**, which is to say, the socially-meaningful stages of our lives which tend to correlate with typical interlaced social settings, role expectations, and identities.

Think of moving from high-school to college. Depending on your specific circumstances, this could have involved

- Moving from home, sometimes a fairly long distance, to come to Stony Brook.
- Ending or starting a romantic relationship.
- Learning a variety of new skills (for instance, your own laundry) and to live on your own, or with a roommate.
- Adjusting to a new pace and style of learning.

We call the connection among these various new social settings, and the socialization that goes with them, a life-course transition.

Such life-course transitions are not limited to your early life; instead, they extend throughout your life. Indeed, it is a common situation for parents (to flip the above example about going to college on its head) to experience "empty-nesting," in which *they* must learn how to be older adults when their children are out of the house and no longer need such intensive parenting.

Finally, stages in the life course (what you transition into and out of) are themselves social constructions. That means that the stages of "childhood," "adulthood," and "retirement/old age," for instance, are not natural or biologically fore-ordained, and instead have varied quite considerably. To get a sense of this, consider that when the United States implemented old-age pensions (called Social Security, and intended to cut poverty among the retired) and the first monthly Social Security Check was issued in 1940, average life expectancy was actually *lower* than the retirement age (average life expectancy was 61.4 for men and 65.7 for women and the retirement age in 1940 was

65.5).[5] By contrast, today, the retirment age is 67, and average life expectancy in the US in 2024 was 79. This means, simply, that there is a group of people who now live on their savings and national pensions for about a decade, on average, whom we call "retirees," which didn't exist with the same structure in your great-grandparents' time.[6]

[5] Source: Social Security Administration.

[6] A little more precisely, we want to know the average life expectancy *at the age of retirement*, not at birth. Today, at retirement age, that life expectancy is about 15 years for men and about 18 years for women. (Source.)

Theories of Socialization

There are two general theories of socialization relevant for many sociologists, and one rich, applied example of their combination, in the work of Howard Becker.

Mead

First, the sociologist George Herbert Mead, building from the classical sociology of (among others) Emile Durkheim, proposed that socialization was a matter of the tension between people's individual impulses (which Mead called the "I") regardless of social context, and their senses of themselves given the social identities attributed to them by others and the reactions by others to one's own behavior (called the "me"). For Mead, the process of socialization was the progressive incorporation of the "me" into peoples' identities, and, therefore, their incorporation of the view of others into the view of themselves.

For Mead, this process can be directly observed in things like children's games. Playing with a very young child, it is common for the child to rapidly (and selfishly) change the terms of the game, or even its substance, over the course of play. However, as children get older and socialization progresses, games become more robust and durable, to the point where they overtake any individual child's desires. Put differently, a point comes where the game continues whether or not any individual playing it would like to be playing something else, or nothing at all.

Finally, Mead also noted that the process of socialization was one whereby the concrete "others" referenced in the construction of the "me" became increasingly abstract over the course of socialization. During primary socialization, others are usually

concrete people—thus, for instance, we wonder "what would my mother think of me doing this?" as our "me" becomes more salient to us. As we pass to secondary socialization, meanwhile, the others become a general picture of what "people" would think of our behaviors, becoming, in Mead's terms, "the generalized other."

Piaget

The second major theorist of socialization is Jean Piaget, who, like Mead, emphasized that socialization is the process of increasingly abstract reasoning. But *unlike* Mead, Piaget's theory only indirectly gestured to socialization by other people, instead stressing direct interaction with the world.

For Piaget, this meant that children pass through several phases, namely

- The sensorimotor phase, in which children learn the boundaries between themselves and the rest of the world (primarily by touching);
- Preoperational, in which children make disordered symbolic representation (babbling before speaking coherently) and egocentric speech (confusing "I" and "you," for instance);
- Concrete operational, in which children gain the ability for basic symbolic interaction and initial abstraction, such as being able to represent things with numbers and manipulate those numbers without directly interacting with concrete representations;[7]
- Formal operational, in which people become capable of highly-abstract forms of reasoning and intellectual manipulation of higher-order intellectual problems that cannot be materially represented.

[7] Concretely, this means being able to answer a question like "What is ten minus five" without counting the numbers on the digits of your hand.

Becker on Socialization: *Becoming A Marihuana User*

To an extent, both of these theories are synthesized and worked through by Howard Becker, in his famous essay "Becoming a Marihuana User." The essay's starting point is to push back

against the idea that Marijuana is *inherently* addictive, and instead to emphasize that "getting high" is the outcome of a process of socialization. Specifically, people must learn

1. How "to smoke the drug in a way that will produce real effects,"
2. How "to recognize the effects and connect them with drug use," and
3. How "to enjoy the sensations [you] perceive."

Collectively, this emphasizes that "being high" is a *social* category that requires socialization and not an inherent *biological* (or neurobiological) category.

Examples of Becker: Getting Drunk and High *For Science*

There are two direct examples that illustrate Becker's theory: grandmas smoking weed for the first time, and young people trying moonshine for the first time.

Interaction

As implied by the previous discussion, people are socialized fundamentally through **interaction**, or the exchange of meaning with one another. Think about it this way: given the amount of your lives that are organized through meaning, and that the vehicle of meaning is symbols and language, and *also* that the links between what is doing the representation (the signifier) and what is being represented (the signified) are (even at their most direct) ambiguous, and (and the least direct) totally arbitrary, how else could you understand the meanings of symbols except for repeatedly interacting with others and the world as a whole?

Interaction is the process through while people exchange symbols and meaning with one another and the world in given social settings.

The Guts of Interaction: Setting, Self-Identity, Social-Identity

Any interaction is composed of three things. First, it must take place in a **social setting**—that is, at a given time and place. The setting carries with it assumptions about what norms apply, and what social roles you and others can be expected to play. Within that setting, an interaction is also composed of social and self-identities giving off cues to one another in that interaction. Consequently, what sometimes seem to be mundane activities in fact contain intricately complex social interactions.

"Normal" Interaction

The vast majority of our interactins are "normal," which is to say that, once we are adequately socialized, they take on the quality of background aspects of our social lives.

In these "normal" interactions, we attend to people's facial expressions, gestures, and eye contact, in ways that are shaped by our own understanding of the nature of the interaction. In some interactions—riding an elevator together with strangers, for instance—we practice **civil inattention**, which is to say we are aware of the presence of others but studiously avoid a direct, attentive interaction with them. (In other words, while we know the strangers are there in the elevator, we put our headphones on, pull out our phones, and avoid making lingering eye contact or initiating a direct conversation.) Likewise, in normal interactions, we monitor the personal space we maintain with others, and while there are some variations, we typically think of people getting physically closer to us as becoming more intimate in their interaction with us. Finally, we coordinate performances in terms of their timing, often using, in modern society, precise technological means to do so.

Normal interactions also have a typical structure. Following the work of Erving Goffman, and particularly his analogy of interactions as being **dramaturgical**,[8] we can see that, in interactions, to give a "good" (persuasive) performance in a role, we usually try to maintain a distinction between the **front stage,** where we give the performance, and the **back stage**,

[8] That is, role performances being like a role in a play or film.

where we prepare for it. And we often attempt to segregate audiences to our performances, which is to say, keep people who have knowledge that might contradict us from being in the same audience of those we are trying to persuade.[9]

[9] If this sounds too abstract, just consider: would you want *your* parents to be aware of every single interaction you had over the last week? Or are there some that you'd *really* like them not to know about?

"Eruptions" of Interaction

While the vast majority of interactions are normal, there are instances where this normal order "erupts." In many of these cases (of simple misunderstanding, for instance), these are recovered by apology, humor, or simply re-framing one's intent. (You might, after forgetting an acquaintance's name, for instance, simply introduce a friend to them to hear them explain your name.)

In other circumstances, however, the eruption of the interaction order is intentional. This can be done for research, as in "breaching experiments," but the far more common case is when an interaction is **vandalized** for strategic reasons. This can occur in many interactions, ranging from panhandling to sexual harassment to organizational interrogations, and can be "recovered" by a variety of means. The first is simply to end the interaction, if possible (which is to say, walk away), or to submit what is being asked implicitly or explicitly. But in modern societies, it is often the case that organizations have explicit routines built into them that can be appealed to for support during interactional vandalism. Thus, in the case of interrogation, for instance, in a well-functioning legal system, one can end intensive interrogation by demanding legal recourse.

Unequal Interactions

As implied above, while many interactions follow a taken-for-granted course, many interactions are also unequal—the social settings in which they occur prescribe some social roles as superior and others as inferior. Consider a typical service relationship, where someone is waiting tables. The social setting defining the interaction as "waiting on customers" means that the waiter themselves is *highly* circumscribed in what they can say or do, and that other people (the customers) have a much

wider range of possible behaviors that are congruent with their roles.

As we will see further in the course, interactions are often stratified by key social categories, including race, class, gender, and national origin.

Mediated Interaction

Consider this moment right now, in which I am writing these words and you are reading them. Strictly speaking, this is one social moment, but it is two moments in time. It is two moments in time in the sense that I am typing these words at one time, and you are reading it at another, but from the point of view of our symbolic exchange—enabled by writing—those moments in time are collapsed together, such that my position in writing these words and you in reading them, in the context of the class, are the relevant difference!

The fact that this fantastic social moment is happening across time and space is facilitated by the **mediation** of our interaction. That is, there is a technological apparatus sitting between the direct, face-to-face cues that we can pay attention to, cue on as part of the taken-for-granted background of our everyday, well-socialized lives, or, in the case of civil inattention, politely ignore.

There are two entailments to this idea. The first is that, when the medium of communication is under our direct control, we will typically attempt to use it strategically to our own advantage. If we feel disadvantaged in an interaction, for instance, we may try to use a medium (such as writing) that exerts less pressure on us compared to face-to-face interaction. Or, given other circumstances, we may wish to attempt face-to-face interaction above all else.

The second is that when the medium of communication *is not* under our control, we may suffer from its effects. One of the most consequential changes in the last twenty years has been the rise to dominance of social media, and there is now increasing evidence[10] that social media consumption has quite negative effects on, among other things, depression and anxiety.

[10] Here drawn from a clever study leveraging the fact that social media–here, facebook–diffused at different rates at different colleges in its initial stages, allowing us to compare the mental health of students where it had been instituted to contemporary colleges where it had not yet done so.